

Hey, everybody. Welcome to your chapter 4 review. In this episode, we're going to talk about strategies behind behavior coaching. And of course, we'll cover the key learning points from the chapter. Your primary goal as a fitness professional is to help your clients adopt a regular exercise program and stay active for the long term. So you need to understand how ready your client is to change and then take the right action at the right time to increase their motivation and commitment.

So how exactly do we work with clients to educate them on the advantages of exercise and create longterm adherence? So how exactly do we work with clients to educate them on the advantages of exercise and create longterm adherence? Well, you need to understand why change is important to the client and how to communicate effectively with them. You need to meet them exactly where they are on their own personal path.

In order to map out a successful intervention, you have to understand what the determinants of exercise are and assess what needs to change within a client to prompt them to exercise consistently. You'll need to get familiar with your client's barriers to exercise adoption and adherence so you can lend the proper support and guidance. There are also a lot of useful theories and techniques to drive behavior change. This chapter explored some of the essential elements to help identify client needs, motivate them, and help them develop self-efficacy.

Behavior change is arguably the most important aspect to clients realizing longterm success. It doesn't matter how good your exercise or nutrition program looks on paper. I mean, if the client doesn't do it consistently or just doesn't do it at all, the work you put into creating it won't even matter. So let's make it matter and utilize the tools NASM is giving you.

By the end of this chapter, you'll be able to summarize client expectations of a certified personal trainer and the fitness environment, assess a client's stage in changing unwanted behaviors, structure initial client sessions for optimal effectiveness, communicate effectively and build client rapport, and implement behavioral change techniques to enhance exercise adherence.

There you have it. Now let's dig in. Despite the benefits of regular exercise and physical activity, most people flat-out don't meet the recommended guidelines. People have a variety of issues with exercise, including the simple act of getting started, and then when they do, easily getting derailed. So everything you do, from the moment you meet a potential client to your everyday interactions with them, should drive them to want to get started and come back for more.

That first impression is critically important. Clients expect professionalism, so it's crucial to build relationships and maintain a facility that supports training competency. To help instill confidence, CPTs should take care to act and dress professionally and ensure the training environment is conducive to longterm adherence. Program design should be based on the client's abilities and address their health concerns and goals.

At the initial consultation, you should uncover any health-related concerns and help clients clarify where they want to go. This should include gaining a sound understanding of their previous exercise experience and what they did and didn't like about the process. Self-efficacy is one of the strongest determinants of physical activity in adults. Most coaching efforts are actually going to be directed at increasing and instilling that in your clients and should incorporate planning and self-monitoring.

Effective judgments and subjective norms can also impact a person's readiness to perform resistance training. So that should also be taken into consideration when introducing that to a client. By the time you begin designing a program, you should be able to assess what the client needs, how ready they are for change, and what techniques would drive positive change.

The transtheoretical model of behavior change is not just a super impressive sounding set of words. It will help provide fitness pros with the ability to assess the stage of change that a client is in. You'll have to figure out each client's stage of change and promote competency in exercise as they start and as they progress.

Let's take a quick look at each stage. Pre-contemplation is when your client does not currently exercise and is not planning to start within the next six months. At the contemplation stage, however, they are softening to the idea. They still haven't started exercising, but they are planning on it. Preparation takes it a step further. They've taken steps toward starting an exercise program and may even be sporadically doing it.

Action is exercise. Your client has started, though they're still in the delicate less than six month stage. And finally, maintenance is pretty much what it sounds like. Your client has been exercising consistently for at least six months. And you're helping them to maintain their motivation and goal setting. Moving on, I'd like to communicate a little more about communication because it's such an important part of your role as a change agent for your clients. A lot of being a good communicator is asking the right questions and then just listening actively.

Active listening shows you have a genuine interest in understanding the client. It involves asking appropriate questions, avoiding distractions, and providing appropriate feedback, which sometimes might just be summarizing what you heard. You have to build rapport with your clients so they trust you and are excited about following your lead. And remember, you have both verbal and nonverbal forms of communication at your disposal. So lean in, smile, make eye contact, and listen.

Another great communication technique is called motivational interviewing. It's a style of coaching that's used to enhance intrinsic motivation for change. It provides directions for how to get clients out of the contemplation phase over their ambivalence and ready to act. Everyone has a different level of readiness for changing a behavior. And motivational interviewing will help you gain an understanding of why your client would want to change and the things that might cause them to feel ambivalent about that change.

You'll use techniques from motivational interviewing, like asking targeted questions and developing a discrepancy between a client's current state and ideal state by assessing readiness, willingness, and perceived ability to change. Behavior Change Techniques, what we call BCTs, are used to enhance the determinants of behavior. There are a variety of strategies to enhance a client's confidence, motivation, and/or self-regulation skills through planning, self-monitoring, and goal setting. Cognitive strategies can also help change behaviors and include positive self-talk, imagery, and getting the clients psyched up before activities.

OK. So this is a good segue to talk about goals. Once you've established rapport and developed an understanding of your client's aspirations and motivations to change, you can help set SMART goals. That's S-M-A-R-T, as in Specific, Measurable, Attainable, Realistic, and Timely. A huge factor in success is measurability on both process goals or daily or weekly tasks as well as outcome goals or the final achievement.

For the best outcomes, decide on longterm, big-picture goals and then develop a series of smaller subgoals that are well defined, trackable, and help drive progress to the primary goal. These progressive subgoals can also build confidence and maintain or enhance motivation through little victories. Look, the best, most effective program is the one that the client will actually do consistently. And that is all influenced by behavior coaching.

Behavioral intentions, outcome expectations, planning, self-monitoring, and goal setting are going to be key factors. If a client struggles with motivation, confidence, knowledge, goal setting, or working around barriers, you should be able to assess those areas and provide strategies to keep them on track. Ultimately, if you can uncover what a client needs and wants and how ready they are for change, that will influence the techniques you recommend in order to direct and guide change for the better.

You'll be amazed at what you can accomplish together. I hope this gave you a better understanding of behavior coaching while you're working toward your own long and short term goals. Until next time, happy studying.